against Manchu rule and foreign oppression. While in its early phase the Three Principles conceded the right of self-determination for China's ethnic groups, this was ignored later.

Sun Yat-sen represented a more Western-oriented liberal democratic approach in the quest for modernity. This had a certain influence among Chinese scholars and intellectuals emerging from the newer institutions of education, in particular Beijing University in the capital, which had been set up during the 100 Days of Reform in 1898. There was also a growing number of young men and women who were studying in universities in Japan and Western countries and looked up to these countries as models for the modernization of China. The great dilemma was that these were also the models complicit in the exploitation and oppression of China.

The fall of the Qing dynasty in 1912 and the establishment of the ROC did not resolve this contradiction. It proved to be a precursor to an extended and violent civil war within China among several regional warlords contending for power. And, superimposed upon this was the protracted war of aggression on China by an imperialist Japan. The defeat of Japan in the Second World War in 1945 only served to intensify the civil war between the communists led by Mao Zedong and the KMT led by Chiang Kai-shek, finally ending in the defeat of the latter in 1949. The KMT retreated to the island of Taiwan and set up a rival government, thus ensuring that the civil war still had a final chapter that had to be written. That remains unfinished business to this day.

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The unfolding events surrounding the fall of the Qing dynasty provide us an idea of the turbulence of those times and the different currents of thought prevalent in China at that juncture. After the humiliating defeat suffered at the hands of the Eight Nation Alliance in 1901, the Qing government was confronted with a series of revolts in various parts of the country. It had formed the New Army in 1901 as a more professional and better-trained, better-paid military force. While it was able to put down some of the rebellions, the unrest was both pervasive and relentless. The death of the